

# GLOSSARY

In this glossary, terms defined within another entry are identified with *italic* type.

**Absolute monarchy** A monarchy in which the king or queen has complete control of the nation. See also *constitutional monarchy*.

**Acquittal** A *judgment* that a *defendant* is not guilty of a crime.

**Act** A *statute* or law that has been formally passed by a *legislature*.

**Act of Parliament** A new law or change to an existing law made by the UK Parliament.

**Action** A formal demand to a *court* of law to settle a dispute between two or more parties.

**Advocate** A lawyer who assists, defends, or argues the case for someone in a *court* of law.

**Amendment** An official addition or alteration made to a law, *statute*, or *constitution*. The US Bill of Rights consists of the first 10 amendments to the US Constitution.

**Appeal** A request to a supervisory *court* to overturn the decision of a lower court.

**Arbitration** A process in which an impartial third party makes a binding decision regarding a legal dispute without it having to be resolved in *court*.

**Assize** A *court* that sat periodically in each county of medieval England.

**Barrister** A type of lawyer in the UK and some other countries with *common law* systems who can appear as an *advocate* in both higher and lower *courts*.

**Bill** A proposal for a new law or change to an existing law that is presented for debate.

**Bill of rights** A formal declaration of the most important *rights* and freedoms that are common to all *citizens* of a country or *state*.

**Canon law** The body of law that regulates the organization of the Christian Church and *codifies* Christian beliefs.

**Case law** Law based on decisions made by *judges* in previous cases. See also *precedent*.

**Citizen** A person who belongs to a city or a bigger community such as a *state* or country.

**City-state** A city which, with its surrounding territory, is also an independent political *state*.

**Civil law** 1) A legal system based on *Roman law* and *codification* rather than *precedent*; used mainly in continental Europe and South America. 2) The branch of law that deals with disputes between private organizations or individuals, not crimes.

**Civil rights** The *rights* of people in a society to equal treatment and equal opportunities, whatever their gender, race, or religion. Examples of

civil rights include the right to vote, the right to a fair trial, and the right to use government services and public facilities.

**Codification** The process of arranging laws into a systematic form such as a *constitution* or a *law code*.

**Common law** The law of the land, derived from neither the *statute* books nor a written *constitution*, but from past *court* decisions based on *precedent*. Common law is the basis of legal systems in most English-speaking countries. See also *civil law*.

**Comparative law** The study of different legal systems by comparing and contrasting them.

**Congress** In the US Constitution, the body forming the legislative arm of the *federal* government. It consists of two elected assemblies: the House of Representatives (or Lower House) and the Senate (or Upper House).

**Constitution** The principles and laws concerning the way in which a country is governed.

**Constitutional monarchy** A monarchy in which the king or queen shares power with an elected *parliament*. See also *absolute monarchy*.

**Contract** A legally binding agreement between two or more parties in which an offer is made and accepted and each party benefits.